

Dr. Urvashi Sahni

Dr. Urvashi Sahni (born 1960s) founded Study Hall Educational Foundation (SHEF) in 1986 and Prerna Girls School, transforming girls' education in India through gender-sensitive pedagogy, digital innovation, and empowerment-focused curriculum reaching 5 million+ children over three decades.

Education

- University of Lucknow
- University of California, Berkeley

Career

Dr. Sahni's journey began with personal tragedy: in 1983, her 24-year-old cousin died by burning in what was reported as an accident but Urvashi suspected was domestic violence. With no support systems available for abused women, she founded Suraksha (Safety) - Lucknow's first women's organization and Uttar Pradesh's first family counseling cell. This earned her the National Youth Award in 1987. In 1986, she established Study Hall School in Lucknow, which evolved into the Study Hall Educational Foundation (SHEF). Her vision expanded to Prerna Girls School, offering affordable, rights-based education to 1,000+ girls from urban slums, and Vidyasthali School in rural areas. Digital Study Hall (DSH) leverages technology to disseminate high-quality teaching content to underserved schools. She also founded Grameen India Foundation and DiDi's social enterprises, providing sustainable livelihood training to women. As President and CEO of SHEF, Dr. Sahni has impacted 100,000+ teachers and 5 million+ children. Her work emphasizes that education must be empowering, not merely informative, particularly for marginalized girls facing patriarchal barriers.

Awards and Recognition

- Social Entrepreneur of the Year India 2017 (Schwab-Jubilant Bhartiya Foundation)
- BBC 100 Women 2017 - most inspirational and influential women worldwide
- Schwab Foundation Social Entrepreneur of the Year 2018 (one of 12 globally)
- Clinton Global Initiative Honorary Member (2014)

Dr. Sahni's Story

- Growing up, Dr. Sahni witnessed how patriarchy limits women's lives. Her cousin's death catalyzed her realization that systemic change requires both support for victims and prevention through education. At Suraksha, she counseled abused women and advocated for legal reforms. At Study Hall, she noticed even privileged girls internalized limiting beliefs about



their capabilities. This led to Prerna Girls School's revolutionary model: girls from slums studying in safe, affirming environments where they're encouraged to dream big, question norms, and become leaders. Dr. Sahni challenges the binary between 'empowerment' and 'education' - true learning transforms consciousness. Her curriculum teaches boys to examine patriarchy's costs to them, fostering new conceptions of masculinity rooted in empathy and equality. For girls, education means claiming voice, agency, and space in public spheres. Her book 'Reaching for the Sky: Empowering Girls Through Education' (Brookings, 2017) documents this journey. Through theater, arts, and dialogue, students explore complex social issues. Alumni become teachers, doctors, entrepreneurs - many the first in their families to attend college. Dr. Sahni's impact extends beyond classrooms: she influences policy as non-resident fellow at Brookings Center for Universal Education, writes for Hindi and English dailies, and creates children's books celebrating gender equality.

Leadership at SHEF

SHEF operates a comprehensive ecosystem including Study Hall School, Prerna Girls School for urban slum girls, Vidyasthali School for rural students, and Digital Study Hall reaching remote areas. The foundation's gender-transformative pedagogy challenges traditional power structures, teaching boys about positive masculinity and girls about agency and rights. Prerna graduates and their mothers find employment through DiDi's, creating intergenerational change. Dr. Sahni pioneered the 'life knowledge approach' to life skills, moving beyond vocational training to critical consciousness about gender, class, and caste. SHEF has built partnerships with Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh state governments, scaling innovations across public schools. The curriculum integrates academic excellence with arts, critical thinking, and democratic values - students learn to question, not just memorize.